

Harvesting & Processing

Although there are some herbs that may be collected year round, most have a particular growing season and must be harvested and either used immediately or preserved for use in the following year. See the individual entries on pp. 56–283 for harvesting times. Herbs need to be processed quickly to prevent deterioration and retain their healing action.

Harvesting from the Wild

Wild plants offer a free and natural source of herbal remedies. Furthermore, active constituents are often more highly concentrated in wild plants since the herb is likely to be growing in its preferred habitat.

Identification

Proper identification of wild plants is essential. Use a field or wildflower guide to help you. If in doubt, do not pick the plant, as poisoning can result from misidentification.

Ecological & Legal Factors

While common species, such as nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146), may be readily harvested from the wild, many rarer species are under great pressure due to the lack of a suitable habitat. In many countries it is illegal to uproot any wild plant, and certain species may be protected. Although gathering medicinal plants such as gentian (*Gentiana lutea*, p. 99) may be legal in some countries, it will only reduce their future chances of survival in the wild. *Never pick rare or uncommon plants from the wild, even if they are locally plentiful, and do not collect more than*

you will use. Do not harvest bark from the wild.

Before harvesting, consider where the plant is growing and whether it could be contaminated by pollution. Do not collect from roadsides, close to factories, or in areas where crop spraying has occurred.

Harvesting from Your Garden

Cultivated herbs provide a ready supply of fresh material in a controlled environment. Cut perennials carefully so that plants can quickly regrow. Some plants, such as lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*, p. 113), provide two or more crops per year.

General Advice

Harvesting medicinal herbs requires careful planning to ensure the parts are processed in peak condition and fast enough to retain their active ingredients.

Equipment

Ideally, use a wooden tray or open basket for collecting herbs. This prevents the plant being crushed. In the wild, a non-nylon rucksack or

sack may be more appropriate. Always cut with a sharp knife or scissors to minimize damage to the plant and try to handle plants as little as possible. Wear gloves if gathering prickly or allergenic plants, such as rue (*Ruta graveolens*, p. 265).

What to Look For

Collect material from healthy plants, free from insect damage and pollution. It is important to discard damaged plants because they can lead to disease or decay in dried plant material. Do not mix cut plant material to avoid mistakes in identification.

When to Harvest

Gather herbs in dry weather, preferably on a sunny morning after the dew has evaporated. Picking when the plant is at its peak of maturity ensures that it will have a high concentration of active constituents. Unless otherwise stated in the individual plant entries on pp. 56–283, leaves are best collected as they open during the spring or summer months, flowers as they start to bloom, fruit and berries just as they become ripe, and roots in the autumn once the plant has drawn its vitality back beneath ground. Bark must be gathered with great care if the shrub or tree is to survive—in most cases, harvest it in spring or autumn.

The Correct Medicinal Part

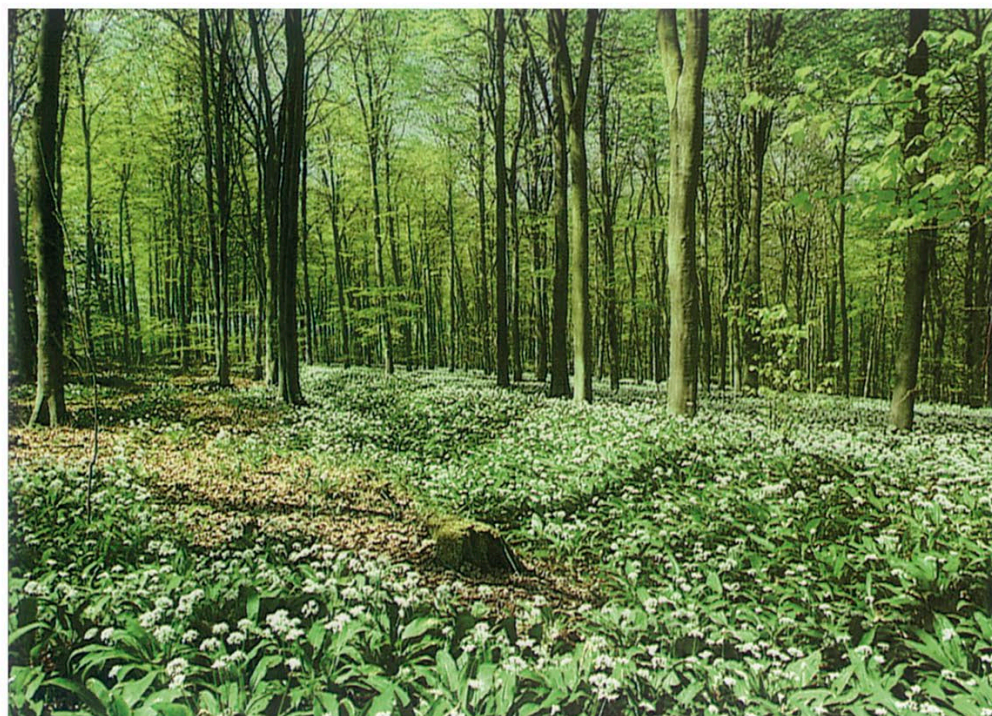
In many cases, different parts of the same plant, for example the leaves and seeds, can have quite different actions and uses. Make sure that you harvest the correct medicinal part of the plant for your purposes.

Processing Quickly

Only collect plant material that you will be able to use or process immediately after harvesting. This is because fresh plant material deteriorates very quickly and the medicinally active constituents are often the first to be affected. In particular, aromatic herbs can lose their volatile oils within hours. Salad leaves and culinary herbs are best eaten right away to make the most of their nutrients, although they can be stored for a few days in a plastic bag filled with air in a refrigerator.

Storing Herbs

It is vital to store dried herbs properly or they will not last. Leaves, flowers, roots, and other parts should be stored in sterilized, dark glass containers with airtight lids. They may also be stored in new brown paper bags, which must be kept dry and away from light. Metal and plastic containers are inadvisable because they may contaminate the herb. If stored in a cool, dark place, herbs can be kept for about 12 months after harvesting. Herbs frozen in plastic bags can be used for up to 6 months. Label the container with the herb, source, date of harvesting, and strength of preparation if appropriate. Watch out



Ramsons can be found carpeting shady sites in damp woods in Europe. The bulb and aerial parts are harvested in early summer for their antibiotic, healing properties.